MAHARASHTRA

NIGHTMARE AT NASHIK BPO

An alleged 'love jihad' case explodes on Maharashtra. From a tech giant's plush office



EYE OF THE STORM Ashwini Chainani remanded to judicial custody at Nashik district court, Apr. 15

MAYUR BARGAJE

marriage from her, and the two had a showdown when this came to light.

Her family approached political workers; the police complaint ensued. A top cop says another accused, Toufiq Attar, allegedly blackmailed and exploited the victim after threatening to reveal her relationship to her family and society. Shaikh, Attar and Nida Khan, an HR manager still at large, have also been charged with hurting religious sentiments by making derogatory remarks about Hindu deities.

SNOWBALLING CHARGES

Then, eight more women victims and a man came forward and filed complaints with Mumbai Naka police station. That trio of accused apart, Shahrukh Hussain Shaukat Qureshi, Raza Rafiq Memon, Asif Ansari and Ashwini Chainani have been arrested, the last an HR official charged with failing to respond to a victim's complaints on inappropriate advances by Memon and Qureshi, discouraging her from escalating the issue, and for siding with the accused. All this while the mandated organisational safety mechanisms were all in place.

Takeaways

- **TCS Nashik shuts ops after explosive 'love jihad' case**
- **Charges include rape, sexual/ religious offences**

The FIRs allege the accused deliberately targeted those belonging to other faiths, made demeaning comments on Hinduism, glorified Islam in conversion bids, made vulgar comments about women colleagues, touching and leering at them, and asking personal questions. A male employee charges he was forced to eat non-vegetarian food and pray in the Islamic way, four women have complained of sexual harassment, three have claimed both. The first victim, who was reportedly shaken up and needed counselling, has also invoked the SC/ ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. Women cops in plainclothes went to the office and counselled other victims.

An SIT is in place, and the Anti Terrorism Squad and NIA have been sounded out for possible linkages. Advocate Baba Sayyad, representing some accused, says many charges are on minor incidents from two-three years ago, being blown up and clubbed together in a string of FIRs filed within days, after the first case acquired a political colour. "They had friendly relations," he says.

Politically, the fire wasn't friendly. Saying "all the victims are Hindus and Marathi", Ajit Chavan of the BJP taunted the Thackeray cousins on their silence. The Devendra Fadnavis government's recent anti-conversion bill has got its first big talking point. ■